

The Crossroads of the Earth

After so many reminders of God's love for all creation—in particular, all humankind—the story of Joshua can be quite off-putting, as we've already shared.

God has trained, modeled, and disciplined His people what it should look like to be followers of Him. By loving God and loving others, the world should be on its way to putting things back together the way they were intended to be.

Yet, throughout the Story of Torah and as we continue our way through the Tanakh, this is not how the story always goes. As the book of Joshua walks us through the Israelites taking up residence in the land of Canaan, we also see it divided up between 12 tribes, not just to live in and live prosperously—but a place to take up and act in their partnership with God.

**God places
His people at
the crossroads
of the earth**

So, to make his point again, God places his people at the crossroads of the earth—the *shephelah*—the highway to blessing *all* nations. Just by placing his Kingdom of priests at the intersection of all people, God isn't just caring for and fulfilling his promise to the descendants of Abraham, he is calling them once again to bless the world.

Some of us may have been shocked to hear that the “land of milk and honey,” the Promised Land, was not just a land flowing with ready-made blessings. It was a land where the people were blessed enough to do the things that God had called them to do. It was a land, a gift, that came with a responsibility. And, what happened when they ended up forsaking this responsibility? I guess, go look for the tribe of Dan in Revelation as is pointed out in the podcast.

**It was a land, a gift, that
came with a responsibility.**

When reading about this calling, this responsibility, to consciously place ourselves at the city gates or crossroads of the earth, I can't help but think of my good friend, Jen. Jen lives in a central area of our city. She is blessed with wonderful children, a beautiful, classic home, and many friends. When you look at her, it would be easy to call her blessed and observe her day in and day out sipping iced tea on her front porch watching flowers bloom in her own promised land. (Her life is not perfect by any means, but you get the picture.)

Yet, her home, and the church just across the street where she works, nestled in this quaint neighborhood, is also at what many would call a central hub in our city. There's a high

school just across the street and a junior high up the road. It's near the university, hospital, parks, and biking paths—and also where you'd find many individuals experiencing homelessness.

In the episode, Marty and Brent paint a picture for us of the city on a hill, much like what we hear from Jesus in Matthew. Imagine being the poor, wandering in the blazing heat, and then turning to see the lights of a city—finally. A sign of hope and respite and safety lying within its walls and behind its gates.

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So what has Jen done with the place she resides? She opened her home to teenagers at that nearby high school, loving on many of them who lost more than one friend to suicide over the past year. And as she joined the church staff, she found herself serving breakfast and coffee with a side of love to the homeless on weekdays. No strings attached. No judgment. Just meeting needs, and seeing each person as they are.

Beyond Jen's work, this church opens its arms to many we might call the foreigner, the orphan, the widow, as well as those seeking justice after their release from prison, those new to the country needing a place to plant and harvest crops, and those needing food from the food pantry every week. Their garden produces berries, tomatoes, and pumpkins used for homemade jams, salsas, and prizes for children at the annual community-wide October event. And their role as a crossroad of the community doesn't end there. Yet, most of these ministries began with the calling of an individual or two, much like Jen, looking at the place they reside, their little corner of the world, and accepting the responsibility to bring shalom to others.

God has given us all something to steward. God gives you something to do that only you can do, to bring that wisdom and provision—and to point the world to Jesus.

PRAYER

*With every blessing I've been given, may I see it as a way to bless others,
stewarding creation with radical hospitality.*

*May I occupy the crossroads of the earth, making it a bit better today than it was yesterday.
Make me a city on a hill, a light in the dark, a city gate,
where people are fed, clothed, and cared for—reminded of their belovedness.*

*May we not abandon Your call, but reside in the midst of all people, all nations, all creation,
in a world that needs a place to look to find You.*

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

Take time to review: dig into the Text of Joshua beyond the battle of Jericho. What could you memorize or study more deeply? What do you notice about the division of land?



COMMUNITY

Think back to your group conversations, wherever they occurred. As a group, where do you see each other called? How does your group partner with God in healing the world?



DISCIPLESHIP

Is there anyone you're taking with you into these new places? This book is one that turns many young people away—how might the imagery of crossroads of the earth impact this?



WRESTLING

What questions still remain? What resonates with you about the imagery, the geography, or the book itself? What do you want to dig into more?



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 2



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases that we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*True success is developing intimacy with God. In Session 1, we encountered the idea of “Creating Space for God” in our lives. We believe that **if we do our part of creating that space, God will fill it** as He desires. You’re already doing this as you dive into the Text and jump into a place to discuss. God will meet you in these places! Look for places the Holy Spirit can do work in and through you as you go about your everyday life.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

*We believe that young adults are shaping the **future of this world**. Jesus modeled a ministry of discipling young adults, and that approach has and will work. If you are a college student who is listening, we want this material to be directly helpful to your pursuits. If you are not a college student, we want to challenge you to come alongside one and work together.*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*This isn’t only for church or Bible study; this is about what we do every day. How we do our job and how it may take advantage of or bring life to others is something God says is central to our presence in the world. Justice is very much something God cares about. Does our physical work (our 9–5 job) bring shalom or chaos? Does it exploit creation? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can provide relief to others. **The work we do every day is sacred and matters!***